this new material in various family collections, the National Army Museum in Chelsea and the British Library.

Here in Delhi, for the last four years I have been trawling through the voluminous records of the 1839–42 occupation in the Indian National Archives which contains almost all the correspondence, memoranda and hand-written annotations on the subject generated by Lord Auckland's administration in Calcutta as well as that of his army. Among the highlights I found there are some previously unpublished private letters of one of the principal British actors in the story, Alexander Burnes; an inquiry into British army atrocities which reads like a Victorian version of Wikileaks; and some very moving court-martial records of sepoys who had been enslaved, had managed to escape and had then faced charges of desertion when they eventually succeeded in returning to their regiments.

The Indian National Archives also contained the previously unused and untranslated Persian-language account of the war by a returned Persian secretary who was attached to one of the British officials involved in the war, Munshi Abdul Karim's *Muharaba Kabul wa Kandahar*. Munshi Abdul Karim says he embarked on the project of writing the history in the early 1850s 'hoping to drive away the loneliness of old age, and to instruct my children and grandchildren in the many curiosities of the world', but adds, in what could be taken as a coded call for an uprising against the Company in India, that 'the events now seem particularly relevant to Hindustan'.[6] Such an uprising did indeed follow in 1857, and first broke out in regiments where the sepoys had been deserted by their British officers during the 1842 retreat from Kabul.

In the Punjab Archives in Lahore, Pakistan, I mined the almost unused records of Sir Claude Wade, the first Great Game spymaster, under whose care the North West Frontier Agency was created in 1835. Here can be found all the reports of Wade's network of 'intelligencers' scattered around the Punjab, the Himalayas and over the Hindu Kush as far as Bukhara. The Punjab Archives also contained all the correspondence relating to Shah Shuja's exile in Ludhiana and his various attempts to return to the throne of Kabul.

Among the Russian sources, I managed to get access to the printed records of Wade's Tsarist counterpart, Count Perovsky, and his protégé Ivan Vitkevitch. Vitkevitch's papers have always been assumed to have been destroyed in his St Petersburg hotel room just before he blew his brains out,